

this night, under the Lahore sky, it was clear, it still does.

Walk through Lahore's cricket museums

Lahore, with its deep-rooted cricketing culture, preserves the sport's rich legacy through two unique museums. One, curated by Yahya Ghaznavi at the National Cricket Academy, is run by the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) and showcases the 1992 and 2009 World Cup trophies along with rare memorabilia. The other, founded by Najum Latif at the Lahore Gymkhana ground, captures the game's early history in Pakistan.

Walking through Bagh-e-Jinnah, where Pakistan played its first international match in 1948, history whispers through old photographs. The Gymkhana ground, where the PCB was founded in 1949, is home to Latif's passion project. Inspired by a visit to Lord's, he set up the museum in 2003, collecting blazers, ties, and signed memorabilia from greats like Majid Khan, Fazal Mahmood, and Imran Khan.

The PCB museum, meanwhile, feels grander, with trophies, gloves, and jerseys on display. A surprising find — a cap worn by India's Roger Binny from the 1983 World Cup squad — adds to the nostalgia.

Latif worries

about the future, hoping the club members will continue preserving history. As I explore both museums, the artefacts, autographs, and photographs remind me of cricket's timeless charm. The legacy of the game lives on in these spaces, where past and present converge in a tribute to Pakistan's cricketing journey.

Shayan Acharya

Revisiting cricket's oasis

The Dubai International Cricket Stadium has firmly established itself as the Middle East's cricketing hub, hosting two ICC finals in four years — the 2021 T20 World Cup and the 2025 Champions Trophy.

Yet, for fans who grew up in the late 1980s and 1990s, cricket in the Arabian Peninsula will always be synonymous with Sharjah.

After three weeks in Dubai, the Diary made a nostalgic trip to the Sharjah Cricket Stadium. As one nears the venue, the sight of its iconic canopies brings back memories of Tony Greig's famous commentary: "They are dancing in the aisles in Sharjah," during Sachin Tendulkar's 'Desert Storm' knock against Australia in 1998. A sign at the entrance proudly declares: "Welcome to the home of cricket in the UAE." However, time has not been kind to Sharjah. Despite holding the world record for most

ODIs and recently hosting its 300th, between South Africa and Afghanistan in November 2024, it feels left behind. Dubai and Abu Dhabi's modern stadiums have taken over, and apart from some minor branding updates, Sharjah shows little sign of evolving with the times.

During the visit, a two-day match featuring UAE's top players — overseen by head coach Lalchand Rajput — was underway as part of preparations for the 2026 T20 World Cup qualifiers.

Once a battleground for cricket's biggest names, Sharjah's legacy also carries a darker side. The match-fixing scandal of 2000 cast a shadow over the venue, and India has not played an international game here since. However, modern-day Indian stars got a taste of the ground during the IPL in 2020 and 2021.

While it would be nostalgic to see top-tier international cricket return, Sharjah's small dimensions struggle against today's power-hitting era. As witnessed in the IPL, batters regularly clearing the ropes made six-hitting feel routine, even dull.

In a way, Sharjah has served its purpose, and it is probably for the best that international cricket has moved on.

S. Dipak Ragav



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